

USD 492, FLINTHILLS SCHOOL DISTRICT

RECOGNIZING SUICIDE IDEATION

Warning signs are observable behaviors (online and offline) that may signal the presence of suicidal thinking. They might be considered a cry for help or invitations to intervene, and they may differ by age group, culture, and even by individual. Warning signs signal the need to ask directly about suicide. If suicidal thoughts are present, then suicide interventions will be required. Below are some examples of warning signs.



Suicide Statements

- It has been estimated that up to 80% of all suicide victims have given some clues regarding their intentions. Both direct and indirect statements need to be taken seriously. See examples below:
 - Direct: *"I want to kill myself."*
 - Indirect: *"You won't have to worry about me for much longer."*



Suicide Notes and Plans

- The presence of a suicide note is a very significant sign of danger. The more in-depth plan a youth has, the greater the risk of suicidal behavior.



Prior Suicidal Behavior

- Prior suicide behavior is a powerful indicator of future suicide behavior. Thus, anyone with a history of suicidal behavior should be carefully observed for future suicidal behavior. Examples of suicide behavior include the following:
 - **Suicide attempt:** Any action a youth takes with at least some intent or desire to die as a result. Suicide attempts don't always result in injury or harm.
 - **Interrupted attempt:** A youth starts to take steps to end their own life but something or someone stops them.
 - **Aborted attempt:** A youth starts to take steps to end their own life but stops themselves before lethal action is taken.
 - **Preparatory acts or behaviors:** Any action a youth takes with the intention to die later, beyond saying something about suicide (including suicide rehearsals).
 - **Non-suicidal self-injury (NSSI):** Engaging in self-injurious behavior purely, 100% for reasons other than dying, usually to affect the youth's internal state or external state.

- While NSSI (self-harm) is NOT suicidal behavior, it does increase a youth's risk of suicide and can be seen as a warning sign, especially if the behavior is new or the severity of the behavior is worsening.
- ***Making final arrangements:*** Making funeral arrangements, writing a will, and/or giving away prized possessions may be warning signs of impending suicidal behavior.
- ***Preoccupation with death:*** Excessive talking, posting, drawing, reading, and/or writing about death may suggest suicidal thinking.
- ***Changes in behavior, appearance, thoughts, and/or feelings:*** Depression (especially when combined with hopelessness), sudden happiness (especially when preceded by significant depressions), a move toward social isolation, giving away personal possessions or responsibilities, and reduced interest in previously important activities are just some examples.

In general, warning signs of suicide look like signs of suffering or signs of struggle. They are most often associated with experiences of pain and loss. Not everyone who exhibits warning signs will inevitably experience suicidal thoughts or behaviors.

The most important thing is that all warning signs of suicide, when observed, are not ignored, and are taken seriously.